

The bill you still haven't opened

8 findings · 12-step checklist · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

For anyone with a letter, an app, or an inbox holding a number they've put off looking at for weeks. Opening it feels like admitting they've let this get away from them, so it stays closed.

THE GOAL

You're trying to make the number small enough to look at, not to have the perfect plan before you open it.

CHECKLIST

You're holding the letter, or you have the app open, and you're about to look at the number.

- ☐ Before you open it, **pick one thing about yourself** unrelated to money, a skill or someone who thinks well of you.
- ☐ Write down the number you're afraid it's going to be.
- ☐ **Open it now**, wherever you happen to be.
- ☐ Find the one figure you actually need first: the total you owe right now, not the whole page.
- ☐ Compare the real figure to the number you just guessed.
- ☐ Write the real figure somewhere you'll see it again today: your phone notes, a card, one line on paper.
- ☐ Note which account or bill this is, and the date on the letter or in the app, next to the figure you wrote down.
- ☐ Decide **one single next action**, never a whole plan: one call to make, or one question to write down.
- ☐ Put a real day on the next action you decided on: today, tomorrow, or a specific date this week, not just soon.
- ☐ Tell one specific person, in one sentence, that you looked at it today.
- ☐ Put the letter or your phone down somewhere you'll actually see it again, not back under the pile.
- ☐ If there's more than one unopened bill, write down the name of each one now, even if you don't open the rest today.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** Across real bank accounts, how often people check their balance tends to track their own debt, tending to drop as what they owe goes up.
- 2** You're probably bracing for this to feel worse than it will: across many kinds of bad news, people consistently **overestimate how bad the moment will feel** once it actually arrives.
- 3** Don't wait until you've told yourself a story that makes waiting feel fine: affirming your values afterward won't undo it.

What not looking is actually doing

KNOW

Not opening it feels like a break from the fear, but avoidance works this way for anxiety generally: the relief now is what keeps the fear alive later.

Relief right after avoiding is the mechanism that, in anxiety research generally, keeps people avoiding it long after. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Across real bank accounts, how often people check their balance tends to track their own debt, tending to drop as what they owe goes up.

The data comes directly from account logins matched to real balances, not from what people say about their own habits. [Source 2](#)

Whether this means something is wrong with you

KNOW

Among people who eventually called a UK debt advice helpline, close to four in ten had already waited a year, and over a quarter had let two years pass.

The wait itself doesn't disqualify anyone: many people who ask for real help waited this long too. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

In real account data, people start checking again once their balance turns from negative to positive.

That reversal happens on its own, tracked directly in account records, tied to the number rather than to you. [Source 2](#)

What the reveal will actually be like

KNOW

You're probably bracing for this to feel worse than it will: across many kinds of bad news, people consistently **overestimate how bad the moment will feel** once it actually arrives.

You picture the moment on its own, without everything else that will still be filling your day right afterward. [Source 4](#)

DON'T

Don't wait until you've told yourself a story that makes waiting feel fine: affirming your values afterward won't undo it.

A defensive conclusion forms the moment you draw it, so anything reassuring after that point arrives too late to change it. [Source 6](#)

KNOW

If it's a student loan, your own number in your head is probably off: in one nationwide study, about half of first-year students underestimated their own student debt.

These were first-year students only, so it wasn't old debt they had simply lost track of over time. [Source 5](#)

DO

Name something about yourself unrelated to money right before you open it. Doing it after barely helps.

Reminders of who you are, done before a threat lands, cut the pull to explain bad news away; done after, they barely help. [Source 6](#)

Sources

1. <https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/managing-health-anxiety/202603/avoidance-is-anxiety-s-very-best-friend>
2. <https://www.nber.org/papers/w23945>
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4. https://dtg.sites.fas.harvard.edu/Wilson_Gilbert_2013.pdf
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Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Debt and paying it down at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](https://cheatgrid.com)